apex development bank, providing refinance to SFCs as well as direct financing of individual enterprises, either singly or jointly with other institutions. The Industrial Reconstruction Corporation of India was also formed with its headquarters at Calcutta to look into cases of sick industries. A mechanism was developed to coordinate the activities of these institutions as a consortium to facilitate the requirements of individual companies. By the time Parekh finally left ICICI such coordination had become an established fact. During these years the appraisal procedure was greatly streamlined and through the constitution of a lead institution, common application forms and single mortgage deeds as well as interim disbursement, the entrepreneurs' day-today complaints largely disappeared.

POSTSCRIPT

Today ICICI no longer exists. What is flourishing, however, is a financial services group offering a wide variety of products and services, both directly and through a number of subsidiaries and affiliates. ICICI's journey from a development finance institution offering only project finance, to a financial conglomerate of astonishing size and diversity would require a separate book. Here, we will have to rest content with a very brief account.

ICICI's course started to change in 1996 when ICICI Bank, which was conceptualized during the tenure of N. Vaghul (who was at the helm of ICICI for eleven years), commenced business. During K.V. Kamath's tenure as Managing Director, the name Industrial Credit and Investment Corporation of India Ltd was changed to ICICI Ltd. In 2000, ICICI launched retail finance— car loans, house loans and loans for purchasing consumer durables. In 2001, ICICI Bank became the first company and the first bank or financial institution from non-Japan Asia to list its stock on the New York Stock Exchange. In the same year it announced a merger with the Bank of Madura.

With rapid changes in the Indian banking industry engendered by keen competition, the widespread use of information technology, and the move towards universal banking, the managements of ICICI and ICICI Bank decided that the reverse merger of ICICI with ICICI Bank would be in the best interest of both institutions. It would also create the optimal legal structure for the ICICI's group universal banking strategy. The merger, it